

AP

A YEAR TO REMEMBER

- Till Boxing Day, Kohli had scored 1,934 runs in 34 innings at an average of 66.68, with 9 fifties and 8 tons, in 2023
- The year saw Kohli become the first cricketer to score 50 ODI tons, going past the record of Sachin Tendulkar
- Kohli is the first player to score over 700 runs in a cricket World Cup
- His 765 runs in 11 WC innings, with 3 tons and 6 fifties, came at an average of 95.62
- In early 2023, Kohli reached 25,000 international runs, scored in 549 innings–28 innings less than the previous record held by Tendulkar. He crossed the 26,000 runs mark too–again the fastest to do that

the tide. Blending strategic aggression with situational adaptability—each inning a crescendo that braids old-style watchfulness with modern derring-do—he has excelled in a format bristling with heavy-handed machismo. The supple wrists come into play in defence and the trademark off-drives; the bottom hand helps swipe balls to the legside fence. Then there's the relentless pursuit of singles and twos, a constant flicker. That run-making machinery of many moving parts is what goes into his records—like his unflagging prolificity at IPL.

Despite his pursuit of white-ball excellence, his steely desire to excel in cricket's toughest format didn't diminish one bit. Perchance the milestone that most satisfied the true-blue Test romantic in Kohli may have been his Test ton versus Australia in March. His 186 in Ahmedabad, though it came on a featherbed, signalled a self-willed course correction—it was his first Test century after a scarcely-believable gap of three-and-a-half years. The only thing that could possibly have topped that was if his three tons and six 50-plus scores had earned India a World Cup. As the Men in Blue froze against a canny Pat Cummins and his well-knit unit in the final, Kohli's 54 off 63, alongside K.L. Rahul's 66 off 107, came in for plenty of bad press for their timid approach. Those who have seen Virat ply his trade long enough would argue that the one thing the Delhi lad couldn't be faulted with was 'timidness'. Nor did that trademark Kohli aggro ever ebb, as a bust-up against Afghan pacer Naveen-ul-Haq in the IPL showed. Still, the Kohli of 2023 was a senior statesman, not the untamed fire-eater of the past. At the World Cup, the 35-year-old, dipping into the sageness born of experience, asked the Delhi crowd not to heckle the Afghan for what he might have said eight months ago on a humid night in Lucknow. Quite in the fitness of things. For, if 2022 marked VK's return to form after a 1,020-day-long dry spell, 2023 firmly re-established him among the best all-format batters in world cricket now—a short-arm jab away from a place in an all-time pantheon. ■